Plugging the Gaps

With the border secure, Honecker applied the same enthusiasm to shoring up the Wall, which reshaped the contours of Berlin for 165 kilometres, following old Prussian district boundaries. As well as vast amounts of materials, the other requirement to maintain progress was, of course, money. And there was no constraint on the amount available. Of the total costs of DDM1.822 billion incurred by the GDR between 1961 and 1964 for the operation of national border installations, DDM400 million (22 per cent) was channelled into the construction and upkeep of the Berlin Wall.

On a normal day, around 2,300 soldiers were deployed directly at the border. In addition to the staff in Berlin-Karlshorst, the border command – made up of seven regiments – had garrisons in Treptow, Pankow, Rummelsburg, Hennigsdorf, Gross-Glienicke, Babelsberg, Kleinmachnow, Wilhelmshagen and Oranienburg. Each regiment had five companies, as well as an engineer, intelligence officers, transport unit, grenade launchers, artillery battery, reconnaissance platoon and a flamethrower platoon, as well as a squadron of 990 guard dogs.

As time went on, the flimsy barbed wire was replaced with a 10ft-high concrete barrier, jagged steel girder tank traps, anti-tank ditches, nail traps and watch towers.1 At the Brandenburg Gate sufficient funds were made available to build a second wall behind the original using concrete slabs weighing three tons, while on Wilhelmstraße – where the barrier cut across the road – a huge poster was hung up, reading: ‘Whoever attacks us will be destroyed.’ To deter ‘irresponsible and annoying’ West Germans from pelting border guards with rocks, Honecker approved the deployment of several water cannon trucks,2 the drenching’s caused many protestors to avoid engaging in demonstrations at the Wall.3

Looking back, Honecker’s exhilaration about this period was palpable. ‘We stopped the bloodletting of the GDR that way. It was in the interests of